

Crime Data & Statistics in the United States:

A Research Guide

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Doing Research on Crime, Finding Data & Statistics

This guide was developed for those searching for local, regional, and national data and statistics on recorded criminal activity in the United States.

This collection of resources is not exhaustive but provides a solid foundation for open-source research. Some of the sources are good for exploring crime in a defined area, while others may be more appropriate for gaining a wider understanding of crime. Links to data sources that contain agency level statistics, surveys, reports, and archival information, as well as information on publications, research, and topical findings are included.

Ease of use will vary depending on factors such as familiarity with data parsing tools, keyword selection, limitations like legally restricted or withheld data, and errors of interpretation. Finding the correct resource if specific data is sought may require thorough review and analysis of several other resources.

Many policing agencies do not report crime data due to lack of funding and resources, workforce imbalance, and the impact of geographical distance from expertise. Other agencies have lapses in their ability to report data in specific formats when learning new reporting standards and implementing more powerful software. In addition, many crimes go unreported. Considering these issues, this guide may not result in complete information. However, it will serve as a broad access point to the information about crime that is currently available.

Finding Crime Data & Statistics Locally (City, County, and Regional Resources)

- [Google Search](#)

One of the easiest ways to begin searching for crime data in a smaller geographical area of interest is to use a tool you may already be familiar with, a Google search. By entering the search terms ["open data portal" AND "crime data" AND "enter the name of your city, county, or region here"] into Google, you may be able to gain access to raw data files made available to the public via city, county, and regional interagency databases. For example, entering "open data portal crime data Denver" returns the [Denver Open Data Catalog:Crime](#). Entering "open data portal crime data San Diego County" returns the [SANDAG – Open Data Portal](#).

Finding Larger Sets of Crime Data & Statistics (State and National Level Resources)

- [Federal Bureau of Investigation Crime Data Explorer](#)

The FBI's Crime Data Explorer can be used to research crime by state or nationally. Additional data filters are available in select datasets to also narrow results to the locale (agency) that collected the original data. Data here can be downloaded in .csv format but is also displayed in charts and graphs for quick reference.

- [Google Search](#)

Google can also be used to locate larger sets of data. However, some additional search terms will return state level data sets more accurately. The first part of the search string remains the same but the words "state of" and "catalog" are added. For example, entering "open data portal crime data state of Florida catalog" returns the [Florida Department of Law Enforcement \(FDLE\) Annual State Summary Crime Data Reports](#).

Finding Journal Articles, Publications, & Other E-Resources on Crime Data by Topic

- [Bureau of Justice Statistics \(BJS\)](#)

Explore data sets by topic, learn about funding opportunities for justice programs related to data and statistics, access data tools, and discover BJS and grant funded research and reports. Of note is the BJS data made available through the [National Crime Victimization Survey \(NCVS\)](#).

- [National Archive of Criminal Justice Data \(NACJD\)](#)

Data on crime and criminal justice in the United States has taken many forms, whether they be analog or digital. The NACJD works as a data clearinghouse to preserve data, old and new, and to make crime data and non-crime law enforcement data accessible for research.

- [National Center for Juvenile Justice \(NCJJ\)](#)

At the top of the page, select 'Publications' to retrieve resources for information specific to juveniles. For general browsing of current information use the 'Newest Publications' and 'News Feed' links near the bottom of the home page.

- [National Institute of Justice \(NIJ\)](#)

The NIJ evaluates justice needs, performs research on how to meet those needs, and then informs public safety agencies on ways to advance justice and best practices therein. Information on national conferences, reports on crime by topic, and other resource gathering materials can be found here.

- [NCJRS Virtual Library](#)

Use the 'Search' tool to find articles, reports, and government sponsored research on crime using the search filters. Abstracts are usually free of charge, but full text materials may require payment.

- [Office of Juvenile Justice and Delinquency Program](#)

Links to various data analysis tools for research on juvenile crime, victimization, and the juvenile justice system.

- [Prison Policy Initiative](#)

In the top menu, select the header 'Data' to explore carceral data sets by topic. Data sets are also made available by state, county, district, city, zip code, neighborhood, and more.

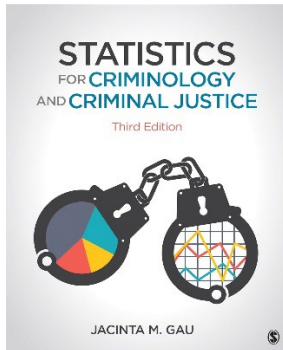
- [United States Sentencing Commission Interactive Data Analyzer](#)

A public dashboard that allows users to visualize sentencing data according to fully customizable parameters utilizing well thought out and organized menus and filters. Data is updated periodically, and the most recent date of publication is posted. Confidential, case-specific information is not available here.

- [U.S. Department of State, Office to Monitor and Combat Trafficking in Persons](#)

Annual, downloadable Trafficking in Persons (TIP) data, as well as fact sheets on how to understand issues of trafficking are made available at no additional cost to the public. Use the menu on the right to see information from years past.

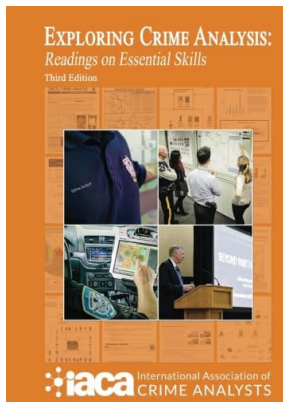
Books on Understanding Crime Data & Statistics



[Statistics for Criminology and Criminal Justice 3rd Edition](#)

ISBN: 978-1506391786

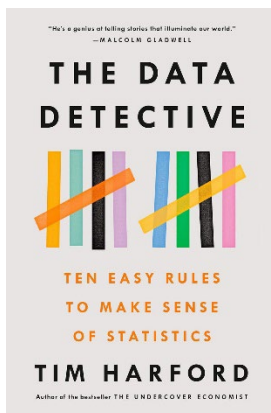
Publication Date: March 16, 2018



[Exploring Crime Analysis \(3rd Edition\)](#)

ISBN: 978-1977937186

Publication Date: October 3, 2017



[The Data Detective](#)

ISBN: 978-0593084595

Publication Date: February 2, 2021

Training, Professional Resources, and Expert Analysis of Crime

There are a variety of educational programs through which a certification in crime analysis can be sought. Attendance at the university level is required and classes are taught by local analysts.

Alternatively, international certification can be achieved via the International Association of Crime Analysts for individuals seeking more comprehensive programming. Additionally, there are various TED talks on understanding crime and data for individuals not interested in the professional application of crime data but who seek to gain an understanding of their surroundings for individual purposes.

- [California State University, Long Beach, Crime and Intelligence Analysis Program](#)

This is just one example of a state level certification program offered locally in Long Beach, California. Many other college campuses across the United States offer similar programs. Online coursework may also be available. If interested, please search for one near you using the search term “crime and intelligence analysis certificate program.”

- [International Association of Crime Analysts \(IACA\)](#)

Use the ‘Training’ and ‘Resource Center’ tabs in the top menu to locate information on publications, educational materials, and coursework specifically geared toward professional analysis of crime data and statistics. Membership may be required for access to some materials.

- [TED, Playlist, Making Sense of Too Much Data](#)

Discover videos and articles that address the modern use of data and its impacts.

- [TED, Playlist, Crime](#)

Learn more about crime and its effects on various communities with these videos and articles.